

Continual Service Improvement



Continual Service Improvement (CSI)

- This is a separate stage of the lifecycle, but it doesn't work in isolation
- Perhaps even more than any of the other stages, this lifecycle stage affects the whole approach for service management
- The desire to improve is often the driving force behind using the service lifecycle in an organization, although it may not be recognized as such at the start



Purpose of CSI

- The purpose of continual service improvement (CSI) is to continue to support the business with IT services in the face of changing business needs
- In most companies, there are business drivers that cause changes in behavior to meet market forces
- Organizations that do not respond to outside forces or recognize the need to change will usually not survive the rigors of the marketplace
- The same should be applied to the provider of the IT services that support the business
- The idea that an IT service provider will be viewed differently is quite surprising, but this is often the perception in an IT department
- Continual service improvement is there to make sure that the changes in business processes that keep the business alive and thriving are recognized and that the IT services that support those processes change with them



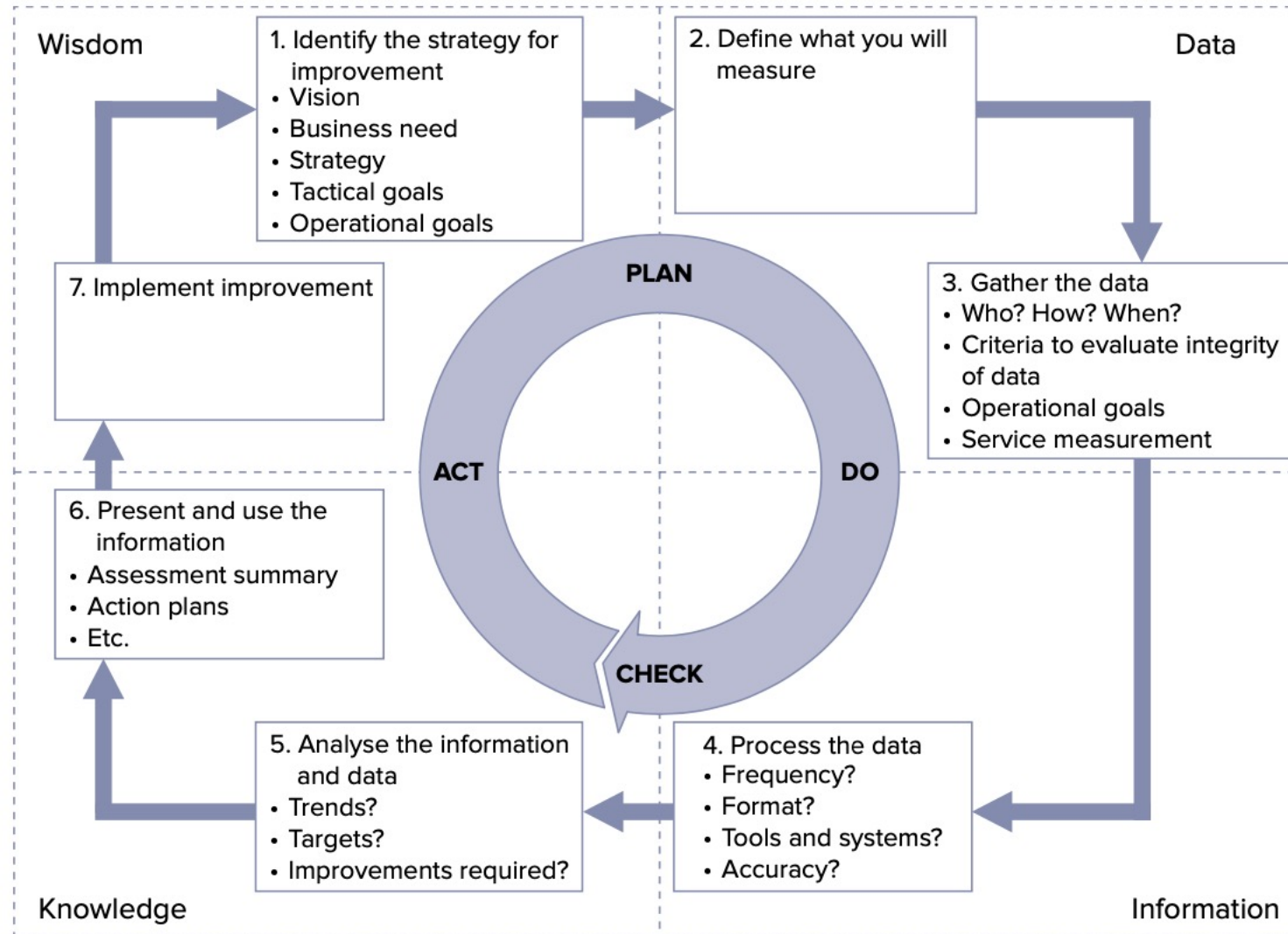
Objectives of CSI

- Review, analyze, prioritize, and recommend improvement opportunities in each lifecycle stage: service strategy, service design, service transition, and service operation, as well as CSI
- Review and analyze service level achievements, according to the service level agreements in place
- Identify and implement specific activities to improve IT service quality, including improvements to the effectiveness and efficiency of the enabling processes
- The overall service quality is partially dependent on the quality of the processes. It can be tempting for IT services to assume that the only metrics that matter are those relating to the technology
- Improve the cost effectiveness of IT service delivery, without negatively impacting customer satisfaction. Customer satisfaction is an important measure of the value of the service being delivered
- Ensure suitable and applicable quality management methods are in use to support the continual improvement activities
- Ensure that the processes in use have clearly defined objectives and measurements, which produce identifiable and actionable improvements
- Understand what to measure, why it is being measured, and what the successful outcome should be



Improvement Process





Improvement Process

- The purpose of the seven-step improvement process is to define and manage the steps needed to successfully implement improvements
- This includes identifying and defining the measures and metrics; the actions required for gathering, processing, and analyzing data; how the results will be presented; and finally the management of the implementation of the improvement.
- The objectives are to do the following:
 - Identify improvement opportunities for services, processes, tools, and so on
 - Deliver cost reductions in providing services, while maintaining the levels of service and outcomes the business requires. It will be important to ensure that any cost reduction does not have a negative impact on the quality of service
 - Identify what needs to be measured, analyzed, and reported to establish improvement opportunities
 - Continually align and realign IT service provision with the required business outcomes, and monitor the service to ensure that your service achievements meet the current business requirements
 - Understand what to measure and why it is being measured; define the success outcome



Identify the Strategy for Improvement

- In this step, you identify the strategy for improvement
- The questions you ask here are concerned with establishing the overall vision for the business
 - What are you attempting to achieve for the business?
 - How can you support the overall business vision, objectives, and plans?
 - What are the future plans for the business: short, medium, and long term?
 - How do your IT services support these goals?
- This analysis will enable you see where the business can best be aided by your efforts
- Triggers and inputs for the improvement process include the following:
 - Business plans and strategy
 - Service review meetings
 - Vision and mission statements
 - Corporate objectives
 - Governance controls
 - Customer satisfaction surveys
 - CSI register



Define What You Will Measure

- This step is directly related to the goals that have been defined for measuring the services and service management processes to support the measurement and CSI activities
- Inputs to this step include the following:
 - SLRs and targets
 - Service review meeting
 - Service portfolio and the service catalog Budget cycle
 - Measurement results and reports (for example, balanced scorecard)
 - Customer satisfaction surveys
 - Benchmark data
 - Baseline data
 - Risk assessments and risk mitigation plans



Gather the Data

- Gathering the data requires having monitoring in place
- It is important to remember that for CSI data capture you are less concerned with real-time monitoring and more interested in the exceptions, resolutions, and trends associated with the data produced
- The tasks associated with this step are as follows:
 - Task 1: Define monitoring and data collection requirements
 - Task 2: Define frequency of monitoring and data collection
 - Task 3: Determine tool requirements for monitoring and data collection
 - Task 4: Develop monitoring and data collection procedures
 - Task 5: Develop and communicate the monitoring and data collection plan
 - Task 6: Update availability and capacity plans
 - Task 7: Begin monitoring and data collection



Process the Data

- During this activity, it is common to use report-generating technology to assist with the transfer of data into information so that it can be analyzed
- Processing the data into information allows more successful analytical techniques and will encourage the use of an overall perspective on the measurement, by associating data groups to an overall service
- When processing data, it is important to consider the following:
 - The frequency of processing the data. This may be driven by the analysis requirements and the ability to capture trends
 - The format required for the output, which will also be affected by how the analysis is carried out and how the information will be used
 - The tools and systems that are used for data processing
 - The evaluation techniques you will use to verify the accuracy of the data



Analyze the Information and Data

- Analyzing the information and data you have produced so far from the process is crucial to enabling its proper use
- Without analysis and understanding the context of the information, you are unable to make informed decisions
- It is important to ensure that the analysis answers questions such as the following:
 - Are operations running to plan? This could be a project plan or service management plans for availability, capacity, or continuity.
 - Are the targets agreed on in SLAs being met?
 - Does the analysis show any structural problems?
 - Are improvements required?
 - Are there any identifiable trends? Positive or negative?
 - Is there an identifiable cause for the trends?



Present and Use the Information

- In this step, you present the answer to the question “Did we get there?” from the continual service improvement approach
- You present the knowledge, represented in the reports, monitors, action plans, reviews, evaluations, and opportunities, to the target audience
- There are four common audience types:
 - **The Customers:** Requiring information on IT services and what will be done if the service provision has failed specific targets
 - **Senior IT Management:** Often focusing on CSFs and KPIs and the actual vs. the predicted performance against targets. This may be presented in the form of a balanced scorecard
 - **Internal IT:** Interested in KPIs and activity metrics to help plan and coordinate operational improvement activities
 - **Suppliers:** Interested in KPIs and activity metrics related to their own service offerings and performance



Implement Improvement

- In this step, you use the knowledge presented in the previous step and combine it with previous experience to make an informed decision about an improvement initiative
- This stage may include a number of actions, from implementing improvement activities to submitting a business case to justify an improvement
- It will involve integration with other service management processes and other lifecycle stages and will include checking whether the improvement achieved its objective

